

SWORN BACHELORS · BOOK ONE

Dangerous Game

A Nigerian romance-suspense drama in 42 scenes. Three sworn bachelors, one billion-naira empire, one mole inside it, and the woman who changes everything.

42

SCENES

~35

MINUTES

LAGOS

SETTING

The cast

DONALD IRWIN

(36). Self-made billionaire, CEO of Every's Conglomerate. Cold, controlling, brilliant. He grew up poor, and his father was killed and robbed on the way home from work.

MICHAEL McCLAREN

(36). Donald's best friend, a famous film director. Charming and always joking.

ROSS

(45). Emma's manager and mentor. Warm and fatherly, and hiding something.

MARCUS VANE

(50). Wealthy businessman with an old grudge against Donald. Smiling and dangerous.

TOBI

(26). Emma's colleague and best friend at work. Funny and loyal, and speaks some Pidgin.

DR. & MRS. REARDON

Emma's parents, both doctors.

YOUNG DONALD, YOUNG MICHAEL, YOUNG GEOFFREY

(12–15).

NARRATOR

A deep, calm voice.

EMMA REARDON

(27). Analyst at Every's. Her parents are both doctors. She is sharp, stubborn and refuses her family's money.

GEOFFREY DUROSE

(36). Donald's best friend. Quiet heir of Durose Holdings and a financial genius.

DEBBY

(38). Ross's girlfriend.

CHARLES OKAFOR

(55). CFO of Every's. Strict and suspicious.

ADAEZE

(30). Donald's personal assistant.

JAMES REARDON

(31). Emma's older brother, a musician the family pushed out.

INSPECTOR BELLO

A police officer.

How to use this PDF. Tap any scene in the contents to jump to it. Every scene ends with a link back to the contents. At 7 cliffhangers there is a **Guess the twist** box: make your guess before you read on, then check the answer key on the last page.

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★	Answer key: Guess the twist	

The Price (cold Open)

EXT/INT. ABANDONED BOATYARD WAREHOUSE, EPE — NIGHT — HEAVY RAIN

Rain pounds a rusted zinc roof. One bulb swings. EMMA sits tied to a metal chair, her blouse torn at the shoulder and her lip bleeding. A phone on an oil drum in front of her lights up. The screen reads: "DONALD."

A man in a black hoodie stands in the shadows. We never see his face. A second voice, smooth and amused, comes through a speaker. This is MARCUS.

MARCUS Answer it, Miss Reardon. Tell him the price.
V.O.

EMMA *(spitting blood, defiant)* He won't pay. Donald Irwin doesn't pay ransoms.

MARCUS *(soft laugh)* Donald Irwin has never had anything worth paying for.
V.O.

Beat.

MARCUS Until you.
V.O.

The phone keeps ringing. Emma stares at it with tears in her eyes. She doesn't move.

NARRATOR Three months ago, Emma Reardon didn't even know Donald Irwin's voice.

SMASH CUT TO BLACK.

SWORN BACHELORS — DANGEROUS GAME

GUESS THE TWIST

Who do you think kidnapped Emma?

☐ A jealous business rival

☐ Someone she trusts at work

☐ Her own family

☐ Random armed robbers

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The Rooftop Pact

EXT. ROOFTOP OF A FACE-ME-I-FACE-YOU BUILDING, AJEGUNLE — NIGHT — 25 YEARS AGO

Three teenage boys sit on a rusty rooftop and look at the far-off lights of Victoria Island. Generators hum below. YOUNG MICHAEL holds a bottle of Fanta. YOUNG GEOFFREY has a textbook on his knees. YOUNG DONALD stares at the skyline and doesn't blink.

YOUNG MICHAEL One day I go buy that whole Victoria Island. Every building. Even the sea.

YOUNG GEOFFREY You can't buy the sea, Michael.

YOUNG MICHAEL Watch me.

YOUNG DONALD *(quietly)* Let's make a promise. A real one.

The other two go quiet. Donald doesn't joke.

YOUNG DONALD One. We become successful. Two. We take care of our families. Three. We never, ever go back to this.

He gestures at the rooftop, the zinc and the darkness.

YOUNG MICHAEL And four... no girls. Girls distract a man.

YOUNG GEOFFREY *(laughing)* You're the only one girls talk to.

YOUNG MICHAEL Exactly. I'm making a sacrifice.

Donald holds out his hand. Michael slaps his on top. Geoffrey adds his.

YOUNG DONALD And five. We protect each other. Whatever it costs.

ALL THREE Sworn.

NARRATOR **Three boys. One rooftop. Five promises. Twenty-five years later, they had kept four of them.**

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The Night That Made Him

INT. ONE-ROOM APARTMENT, AJEGUNLE — NIGHT — FLASHBACK

A kerosene lamp flickers. YOUNG DONALD, 12, does homework on the floor. His MOTHER stirs a pot and keeps glancing at the door.

MOTHER Your papa should be home by now. It's payday. He promised us meat today.

A hard knock. Two POLICEMEN stand in the doorway, hats in their hands. His mother's spoon falls.

POLICEMAN Madam... we found your husband on the road by the bus stop. Robbers. They took everything. His wages... everything.

His mother screams and collapses. Young Donald stands frozen. His eyes go to his father's empty chair.

YOUNG DONALD *(whispering to himself, shaking)* Never again. Nobody will ever take from me again. Never again will I be... powerless.

NARRATOR That night, a boy stopped crying. And he never learned how to start again.

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The King of the Tower

INT. EVERYS CONGLOMERATE — BOARDROOM, 40TH FLOOR, VICTORIA ISLAND — DAY — PRESENT

Glass walls and the Lagos lagoon below. Twelve executives sit in silence. A young MANAGER sweats through a presentation. DONALD IRWIN, 36, in a perfectly cut navy suit, sits at the head of the table. He hasn't looked up from his tablet once.

MANAGER ...so with these projections, we expect a modest growth of...

DONALD Stop.

The room freezes.

DONALD Page four says eight percent. Page nine says six. Which one were you lying about?

MANAGER Sir, it's a typo—

DONALD A typo in a ninety-million-dollar proposal isn't a typo. It's a decision you didn't make. *(standing)* Get it right, or get out of my building.

He walks out. ADAEZE, his PA, hurries after him. CHARLES OKAFOR, the grey-haired CFO, watches him go and narrows his eyes.

ADAEZE Sir, your eleven o'clock—

DONALD Cancel it. And Adaeze? Send me every departmental report from Finance Operations. Ross's team.

ADAEZE Ross is going on leave today, sir.

DONALD *(stops)* Then who's running his team?

ADAEZE *(checks tablet)* A Miss... Emma Reardon. She's been here three months.

Donald repeats the name silently, and his expression doesn't change.

The Daughter Who Said No

INT. REARDON FAMILY HOME, IKOYI — DINING ROOM — NIGHT

An elegant dinner table. DR. REARDON and MRS. REARDON, both doctors, still have their hospital ID cards on lanyards. EMMA, 27, pushes jollof rice around her plate.

MRS. REARDON Dr. Adebayo's son just finished his residency in London. Neurosurgery. Imagine.

EMMA I'm imagining, Mummy.

DR. REARDON Emma, it's not too late. One phone call and you're in medical school by January. I'll pay for everything.

EMMA I don't want your money, Daddy. I have a job.

MRS. REARDON You count other people's money for a man who doesn't even know your name.

EMMA *(putting down her fork)* Then one day he'll learn it.

Silence. Dr. Reardon wipes his mouth slowly.

DR. REARDON This is how it started with your brother. A dream. A guitar. And now—

EMMA And now you don't say his name. Six years, Daddy. James is still your son.

MRS. REARDON *(sharp)* Not at this table.

Emma stands, takes her bag and kisses her mother's cheek anyway.

EMMA I'm not running away like James did. I'm walking. There's a difference.

She leaves. Her father stares at the empty chair beside him, where James's chair used to be.

The Mentor's Gift

INT. EVERYS — FINANCE OPERATIONS FLOOR — MORNING

An open-plan office. ROSS, 45, kind-eyed with greying temples, packs a box. Emma stands beside him, anxious. TOBI, her colleague, hovers nearby with a cup of tea.

ROSS You'll be fine. You're the sharpest person on this floor.

EMMA Ross, I've been here three months. I can't run your department.

ROSS You're not running it. You're protecting it until I'm back. *(He pulls a heavy silver fountain pen from his pocket.)* Here. My first boss gave me this. Sign your first big win with it.

EMMA *(touched)* Ross, I can't take—

ROSS You can. And remember the only rule I ever taught you.

EMMA *(smiling)* "Numbers don't lie. People do."

ROSS Good girl.

His phone buzzes on the desk. The screen shows one letter: "D." He grabs it too fast, and his face goes grey.

EMMA Is everything okay?

ROSS *(forced smile)* It's Debby. She... needs me. Family wahala. *(lifting the box)* Don't let anyone bully you, Emma. Especially not upstairs.

He walks to the lift. As the doors close, he looks back at her with something like regret.

TOBI *(sipping tea)* That man is hiding something.

EMMA Tobi, everybody is hiding something.

TOBI Yes, but his own is sweating.

GUESS THE TWIST

Ross's phone flashed one letter: "D". What's going on?

☐ Just family wahala with Debby

☐ He's hiding something dangerous

The Email

INT. EVERYS — EMMA'S DESK — THREE WEEKS LATER — NIGHT

Montage feel. Emma is buried in files. Missed deadlines show in red on her screen. A colleague slams a folder down: "Client is complaining again." Emma rubs her eyes. The clock reads 11:47 PM.

TOBI Emma, go home. Even the cleaners have gone home. The generator has gone home.

EMMA The quarterly report is due tomorrow, Tobi. If it's bad, they'll say Ross left a girl to do a woman's job.

Her computer pings. A NEW EMAIL arrives. FROM: Donald Irwin, CEO.

Emma and Tobi lean toward the screen together. Emma clicks it open.

ON SCREEN

Be in my office by 10 a.m.

That's the whole message. No greeting and no signature.

TOBI *(whispering)* Ehn. Emma. Write your will.

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The First Meeting

INT. DONALD IRWIN'S OFFICE, 40TH FLOOR — 9:58 AM

A huge, cold, minimalist office. Emma walks in holding her report tightly. Donald sits behind his desk reading her report, which already has red ink all over it. He doesn't look up.

DONALD Sit.

She sits. Ten seconds pass with only the sound of pages turning.

DONALD Miss Reardon. Did you write this, or did it happen to you?

EMMA I wrote it, sir.

DONALD Then you should apologise to it. *(He flips pages.)* Your forecast is optimistic. Your summary is soft. And your department has missed two deadlines in three weeks.

EMMA My department lost its manager three weeks ago, and nobody replaced him. I'm doing two jobs on one salary.

He finally looks up. Their eyes meet for the first time.

DONALD Is that an excuse?

EMMA It's a fact. You like facts, don't you? I read your interviews.

DONALD *(cold)* Careful.

EMMA With respect, sir, you asked me here to tear me down. You've done that. But you haven't asked me one question about the actual numbers. If you had, you'd know page eleven is the most important page in that report, and you skipped it.

Silence. Donald slowly turns to page eleven. His jaw tightens.

DONALD You think you can talk to me like this?

EMMA I think you'd fire me faster if I didn't.

A long beat. Something flickers across his face. It isn't anger. It looks closer to interest.

DONALD Get out, Miss Reardon.

She stands, chin high, and walks out. The door clicks shut.

Donald sits alone. He looks at page eleven. In the margin, in small, neat handwriting, she has written:

WRITTEN NOTE

**Halbrook account — 0.3% variance. Recurring?
Check.**

He reads it twice, then leans back. For the first time in years, Donald Irwin smiles, just slightly.

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After Hours

INT. EVERYS — FINANCE FLOOR — 8:30 PM — SAME DAY

The floor is empty. Emma packs her bag, still shaking with anger. Footsteps echo, slow and expensive. She turns. Donald stands there with his tie loosened and her report in his hand.

EMMA *(startled)* Sir. If you've come to fire me, you could have sent another one-line email.

DONALD Halbrook.

EMMA ...Sorry?

DONALD Page eleven. Your note. Explain it.

EMMA Every month, the Halbrook account loses a little. Point three percent. Too small for an audit to catch. But it's been happening for fourteen months. Same day. Same amount. Numbers don't lie.

DONALD *(quietly)* People do.

She blinks, surprised he finished the phrase.

DONALD Investigate it. Quietly. You report to nobody but me. Not your colleagues. Not Finance. Not the CFO. Do you understand?

EMMA Why me?

DONALD Because you're the only person in this building who looked at that number and didn't look away. *(turning to leave)* And Miss Reardon? Your report was still bad.

EMMA *(calling after him)* Your email was worse!

He keeps walking, but we see him smile.

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Suya at Midnight

INT. EVERYS — SMALL PRIVATE CONFERENCE ROOM — NIGHT — ONE WEEK LATER

Papers cover the table. A whiteboard shows arrows and figures. Emma is barefoot, her heels under the chair, as she draws lines between numbers. The door opens. Donald walks in carrying a newspaper-wrapped parcel. The smell of suya fills the room.

EMMA You... brought suya?

DONALD You haven't left this room in six hours. Adaeze told me.

EMMA Billionaires eat suya?

DONALD *(sitting down and unwrapping it)* I ate suya before I could spell "billion." Sit.

They eat. For a moment, they're just two people at midnight.

EMMA The money doesn't disappear. It moves. Every month, a little goes to a vendor called Crestline Logistics. Crestline has no trucks, no staff and no office. Just an account.

DONALD A shell company.

EMMA And the payments are approved inside Every's. By someone with senior access.

Donald stops chewing.

DONALD How senior?

EMMA Senior enough that if I say the name out loud before I'm sure, I'll lose my job. Maybe more.

He studies her face.

DONALD You have pepper on your lip.

She wipes it, embarrassed. He laughs, a real laugh, rusty from lack of use. She stares.

EMMA You laugh?

DONALD Tell no one. I'll deny it.

The CFO

INT. EVERYS — RECORDS ARCHIVE, BASEMENT — DAY

Long shelves of files. Emma pulls out a box labelled "HALBROOK — 2024–2025." A shadow falls over her. CHARLES OKAFOR, the CFO, stands at the end of the aisle.

CHARLES Miss Reardon. You're a long way from your desk.

EMMA *(composed)* Just... reconciling some old accounts, sir.

CHARLES Halbrook. *(He steps closer.)* Who authorised you to open those files?

EMMA It's part of my department's review.

CHARLES Your department's review doesn't include archive access. *(He takes the box gently but firmly out of her hands.)* Some files are closed for a reason. Young people should be careful what they open.

He walks away with the box. Emma's heart pounds. She pulls out her phone and texts:

ON SCREEN

CFO just took the Halbrook files from me. Is that normal?

Three dots. Then:

ON SCREEN

Nothing about Charles is normal. Don't be alone with him.

GUESS THE TWIST

Who is the mole inside Every's?

☐ Charles Okafor, the CFO

☐ Ross, her mentor

☐ Tobi, her best friend

☐ Adaeze, Donald's PA

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The First Warning

INT. EMMA'S CAR — PARKED IN EVERY'S BASEMENT CAR PARK — NIGHT

Emma throws her bag onto the passenger seat, exhausted. Her phone buzzes. It's an UNKNOWN NUMBER.

ON SCREEN

STOP LOOKING INTO HALBROOK OR ELSE.

She freezes and looks around the dark car park. Pillars and shadows. A security light flickers. Somewhere, a car door shuts.

EMMA (whispering) Who are you?

She locks the doors and starts the car with trembling hands. As she drives off, a black SUV with tinted windows pulls out behind her. Its headlights are off.

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The Photographs

INT. DONALD'S OFFICE — NEXT MORNING

Emma walks in without knocking. Adaeze tries to stop her and fails. Emma slaps her phone on Donald's desk.

EMMA That came last night.

Donald reads the message. His face doesn't move. Then the phone buzzes in his hand with another message: PHOTOGRAPHS. Emma at her apartment door last night. Emma at the supermarket. Emma asleep in her car at a traffic light.

ON SCREEN

WE SEE YOU, EMMA.

Donald's knuckles go white around the phone.

DONALD You got the first message twelve hours ago, and you're only telling me now?

EMMA I handled it.

DONALD You handled it? Someone stood outside your door, Emma!

It's the first time he has said her first name. Neither of them misses it.

DONALD *(pressing intercom)* Adaeze. Two security officers on Miss Reardon. Around the clock. And a driver.

EMMA No. Absolutely not. I'm not your property, Mr. Irwin.

DONALD You're my responsibility.

EMMA I'm my own responsibility! I didn't refuse my father's money so a different man could put me in a cage!

Silence. That hit something in him.

DONALD *(quietly, controlled)* I'm not trying to cage you. I'm trying to keep you alive. Those are not the same thing.

She stares at him and her anger softens.

EMMA ...One officer. And no driver. I like my car.

DONALD Two officers. And you can keep your car.

EMMA You negotiate like a criminal.

DONALD I learned from them.

The Brothers

INT. PRIVATE MEMBERS' LOUNGE, IKOYI — NIGHT

A leather and whisky lounge with a jazz band playing softly. MICHAEL McCLAREN, 36, stylish and grinning, sprawls in an armchair. GEOFFREY DUROSE, 36, calm, in glasses, studies the Halbrook printouts. Donald stands at the window.

MICHAEL So let me get this straight. A junior analyst insulted you in your own office, and instead of firing her, you brought her suya.

DONALD It was a working dinner.

MICHAEL Geoffrey, write the date down. Donald Irwin has broken the pact.

GEOFFREY *(not looking up)* I wrote it down three weeks ago, when he cancelled our golf because of "a report."

DONALD Can we focus?

GEOFFREY *(taking off his glasses)* I am focused. Donald, this isn't theft. Thieves are greedy. They take big and run. This is patient. Small cuts, for fourteen months. Someone is bleeding Every's slowly so your quarterly numbers look weak.

DONALD Why?

GEOFFREY Weak numbers mean a falling share price. A falling share price means your company gets cheap. And a cheap company...

MICHAEL *(no longer smiling)* ...gets bought.

DONALD A hostile takeover.

GEOFFREY And there's only one man in Lagos who hates you enough to wait fourteen months.

All three look at each other. Donald says it like a curse.

DONALD Marcus Vane.

The Man in the Shadows

INT. MARCUS VANE'S MANSION, BANANA ISLAND — STUDY — NIGHT

Dark wood, a fireplace and a chessboard. MARCUS VANE, 50, silver at the temples, in a silk robe, moves a white bishop. Then he picks up a burner phone and dials.

MARCUS She found Crestline.

VOICE ON PHONE I warned her. I sent the messages, like you said.
distorted, male

MARCUS Messages. *(He chuckles.)* Messages are for children. She's still looking.

VOICE ON PHONE Please. She's just a girl. She doesn't know anything yet.

MARCUS Then make sure she never does. Or I'll remind you what happens to Debby.

VOICE ON PHONE *(panicked)* Don't. Don't touch her. I'll handle it.

Marcus hangs up. He looks at the chessboard, lifts the white queen and turns it in his fingers.

MARCUS Donald, Donald. You never kept anything you could lose. *(He smiles.)* Now you have.

He sets the queen down in front of the black king.

A Visit to Ross

INT. ROSS'S HOUSE, SURULERE — LIVING ROOM — DAY

The house is half empty. There are lighter patches on the walls where pictures used to hang. Ross opens the door looking thinner, unshaven and nervous. He brightens a little when he sees Emma holding a bag of oranges.

ROSS Emma! What are you doing here?

EMMA Checking on my mentor. You don't answer calls anymore.

They sit. She notices the bare walls.

EMMA Where's Debby?

ROSS *(too quickly)* With her sister. In Ibadan. For a while.

EMMA Ross, I need your advice. I found something at work. Halbrook. Crestline Logistics. Someone senior is—

Ross's cup rattles against its saucer. He puts it down.

ROSS Emma. Leave Halbrook alone.

EMMA You told me numbers don't lie—

ROSS *(suddenly fierce, grabbing her hand)* I'm telling you now. Please. Leave it. Give it to Mr. Irwin, give it to Charles, give it to anybody, but you walk away. Promise me.

His eyes are wet. Emma is shaken.

EMMA Ross... are you in trouble?

A long pause. He lets go of her hand and forces a smile.

ROSS I'm just an old man who worries too much. Go home, Emma.

As she leaves, the camera stays on Ross. He pulls a second phone from under a sofa cushion. One unread message reads: "Tick tock."

Framed

INT. EVERYS — BOARDROOM — MORNING

An emergency board meeting. Emma has been called in. Charles Okafor stands at the screen with a remote in hand. Donald sits at the head of the table, unreadable.

CHARLES At 2:14 a.m. last Tuesday, someone logged into the Halbrook ledger and moved four hundred thousand dollars to Crestline Logistics. They used this login.

He clicks. The screen reads: USER — E.REARDON.

Gasps around the room. Emma goes pale.

EMMA That's not... I was asleep at 2 a.m.! Ask the security officers outside my house!

CHARLES Convenient. A junior analyst gains access to a sensitive account, and suddenly money moves under her name.

EMMA I'm the one who found the problem! Why would I report my own crime?

CHARLES To control the investigation. It's the oldest trick there is.

Every head turns to Donald. He stands slowly and looks at Emma for a long, painful moment.

DONALD Miss Reardon. Give me your badge.

Emma's face breaks. She can't believe it.

EMMA *(whispering)* You know I didn't do this.

DONALD Your badge. Now.

She unclips it with shaking fingers and puts it on the table. She walks out with her head high as tears run down her face. Charles watches her go with a satisfied look.

GUESS THE TWIST

Did Donald just fire Emma for real?

☐ Yes, he thinks she's guilty

☐ No, he's playing a bigger game

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The Game Inside the Game

INT. EVERYS — STAIRWELL — MOMENTS LATER

Emma storms down the stairs, sobbing. A door bangs above. Donald comes running down two steps at a time and catches her arm.

EMMA Don't touch me!

DONALD Emma, listen—

EMMA You humiliated me! In front of the entire board! I trusted you!

DONALD That's exactly why I did it!

She stops.

DONALD *(lowering his voice)* Whoever framed you is in that building. Maybe in that room. They needed you out. Now they think they've won. And people who think they've won get careless.

EMMA *(realising)* You... used me as bait.

DONALD I used their confidence as bait. You're not suspended. You're invisible. There's a difference.

EMMA You could have told me first!

DONALD Then your tears wouldn't have been real. And Charles would have known.

She slaps him. It echoes in the stairwell. He doesn't flinch.

DONALD *(quietly)* I deserved that.

EMMA *(voice cracking)* Yes, you did.

A beat. They are breathing hard and standing very close.

DONALD Go home. Keep your phone on. And Emma... I never believed it. Not for one second.

The Brother at the Door

INT. EMMA'S APARTMENT, LEKKI — EVENING

Emma sits on the floor eating ice cream from the tub with mascara streaked down her face. A knock. She checks the peephole and gasps. She opens the door. JAMES REARDON, 31, stands there with a guitar case on his back and a gentle smile.

EMMA James?!

JAMES Hello, small madam.

She throws herself into his arms.

EMMA Six years! Where have you been?

JAMES Playing in hotels nobody's heard of. Abuja. Accra. Cotonou. *(beat)* Daddy called me.

EMMA *(shocked)* Daddy called you?

JAMES First time in six years. He said, "Your sister is in trouble, and she won't talk to me. Maybe she'll talk to you." *(smiling sadly)* Then he hung up before I could answer. Typical.

Emma laughs through her tears.

Outside, across the street, the black SUV sits in the dark. A cigarette glows inside it.

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The Balcony

EXT. EMMA'S APARTMENT BALCONY — NIGHT

Later. James plays soft guitar inside. Donald has come by and stands on the balcony with Emma. The Lekki lights spread out below them.

EMMA Why are you really here, Mr. Irwin?

DONALD Donald.

EMMA ...Why are you really here, Donald?

A long pause. He looks out at the city.

DONALD My father worked twelve hours a day. One payday, he was walking home with his wages in his pocket, and someone killed him for it. For a few thousand naira. *(beat)* I was twelve. I stood in that doorway and watched my mother break. And I couldn't do anything. Nothing.

EMMA *(softly)* Donald...

DONALD I built an empire so I would never feel that again. Powerless. *(He turns to her.)* And then a stubborn analyst walked into my office, and suddenly I can't sleep, because someone is taking pictures outside her door.

Silence. She steps closer. He lifts his hand to her face slowly, as if he's afraid she'll vanish. Their lips are almost touching—

CRASH! A brick smashes through the living room window. Glass explodes. The guitar stops.

JAMES EMMA!

O.S.

Donald pulls Emma behind him. The brick lies on the floor with a paper tied around it. Donald unfolds it.

WRITTEN NOTE

LAST WARNING.

Outside, tyres screech away.

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The Login

INT. DONALD'S MANSION, LEKKI — GUEST WING — LATE NIGHT

Emma, wrapped in a blanket, sits on a sofa. James paces. Michael and Geoffrey have arrived. Geoffrey has a laptop open.

MICHAEL *(to Emma, grinning)* So you're the woman who broke Donald Irwin. Michael. Charmed. I've been waiting twenty-five years to meet you.

DONALD Michael.

MICHAEL I'm being supportive.

GEOFFREY I traced the 2:14 login. It used Emma's password, but not Emma's computer. It came from a terminal on the 14th floor.

EMMA The 14th floor? That's our floor. Which desk?

Geoffrey hesitates and glances at Donald.

GEOFFREY The manager's office. Terminal 14-01.

Emma goes still.

EMMA No. That's Ross's office. That's impossible. Ross is on leave. He hasn't been in the building for weeks.

GEOFFREY His key card says otherwise. It was swiped at 1:58 a.m.

EMMA *(standing, angry)* Then someone stole his card! The same way they stole my password! You don't know Ross. He gave me his pen. He taught me everything!

Nobody speaks.

DONALD *(gently)* Emma—

EMMA No. I'll prove it.

The Drawer

INT. EVERYS — ROSS'S OFFICE, 14TH FLOOR — 2 AM

Dark. Emma slips in using Tobi's borrowed badge and a phone torch. She searches Ross's desk. The drawers hold files, pens and an old photo of Ross and Debby laughing. In the bottom drawer, taped underneath, she finds a small black notebook. She opens it. Inside are dates, amounts and the word "CRESTLINE" over and over in Ross's handwriting.

EMMA *(whispering, broken)* No... no, no, no...

The lights SNAP ON. Emma spins around. Charles Okafor stands in the doorway.

CHARLES Put it down, Miss Reardon.

Emma backs against the wall, clutching the notebook.

EMMA *(terrified)* Stay away from me. I'll scream.

CHARLES *(holding up both hands)* Scream if you want. But first, look at this.

He slowly takes out his own phone and turns the screen toward her. It shows a photo of Ross meeting Marcus Vane in a car park, time-stamped two months ago.

CHARLES I've been watching Ross since January. And I thought you were helping him.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The Truth About Charles

INT. DONALD'S OFFICE — 3 AM

Donald, Emma and Charles. Coffee cups.

CHARLES I took the Halbrook files because I didn't know who to trust. Emma was Ross's protégé. I assumed she was his partner.

DONALD And you didn't tell me?

CHARLES You don't trust anyone, Donald. I learned from the best.

Emma stares at the black notebook on the desk.

EMMA *(numb)* He told me numbers don't lie. *(her voice cracks)* He forgot to mention he was one of the people.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The Confession

EXT. ROSS'S HOUSE, SURULERE — RAIN — NIGHT

Pouring rain. Emma bangs on the door. Ross opens it and sees the black notebook in her hand. His whole body sags.

EMMA Was it you? Look at me and say it wasn't you.

Silence. Only rain.

ROSS *(breaking)* It was me.

Emma steps back as if he has hit her.

EMMA Why? Why, Ross?!

ROSS Debby's father borrowed money from the wrong people. Marcus Vane bought the debt. All of it. Then he came to me. Smiling. He said, "Ross, you can pay it with information, or Debby can pay it another way." *(He chokes.)* He sent me pictures of her sleeping, Emma. Sleeping.

EMMA You framed me. You used my password!

ROSS He told me to! I swear I tried to stop you. The messages, the warnings... I sent them so you would quit. So you'd be safe!

EMMA *(screaming through tears)* You taught me everything! You gave me your pen!

ROSS *(on his knees in the rain)* Numbers don't lie, Emma. People do. *(He looks up, destroyed.)* I am the people.

Headlights sweep over them. A black car stops. Donald steps out into the rain with no umbrella and walks toward Ross.

The Deal

EXT. ROSS'S HOUSE — CONTINUOUS

Donald stands over Ross, who is still kneeling in the rain.

DONALD Give me one reason not to send you to Kirikiri tonight.

ROSS *(shaking)* Because I know when Marcus moves. The takeover bid is at the shareholders' meeting on Friday. He has a list of every board member he's bribed. And I know where he keeps Debby's father's debt papers.

Donald looks at Emma. She is soaked, devastated and still standing.

EMMA *(barely audible)* Let him help. For Debby.

DONALD *(to Ross)* You work for me now. Every word Marcus says, I hear first. If you lie to me once, just once, I'll make sure you never see daylight.

ROSS *(sobbing)* Thank you, sir.

DONALD Don't thank me. Thank her.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The King Sees the Queen

INT. MARCUS VANE'S MANSION — STUDY — NIGHT

Marcus watches grainy footage on a tablet. A hidden camera shows Ross entering Donald's car.

HENCHMAN He's switched sides, oga.

MARCUS *(calm, almost pleased)* Of course he has. Weak men always switch sides. *(He swipes to a photo of Emma laughing with Donald on the balcony.)* I've spent fifteen years looking for Donald Irwin's weakness. Money? He has too much. Fear? He buried it with his father. *(He taps Emma's face on the screen.)* And then he goes and falls in love.

He sets the tablet down.

MARCUS Change of plan. Forget the boardroom. Bring me the girl.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The Plan

INT. DONALD'S MANSION — STUDY — DAY

Donald, Michael, Geoffrey, Charles and Ross stand around a table covered in documents.

GEOFFREY Ross feeds Marcus fake numbers. Marcus thinks Every's is weaker than it is. He overpays for shares.

CHARLES Meanwhile, I freeze Crestline's accounts Friday morning. Every naira he stole comes back.

MICHAEL And I make sure every camera and every journalist in Lagos is at that shareholders' meeting. *(grinning)* If you're going to destroy a man, do it in good lighting.

DONALD On Friday, I stand up in front of the shareholders and expose him. With evidence. On live television.

ROSS *(nervous)* Sir... Marcus doesn't lose quietly. When he loses, people get hurt.

Everyone looks at Ross. Donald's eyes move to the doorway, where Emma stands listening.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The Garden

EXT. DONALD'S MANSION — GARDEN — NIGHT

Fairy lights over the pool. Emma sits on the edge with her feet in the water. Donald sits beside her and puts his expensive shoes on the grass.

EMMA Can I ask you something? Am I a project to you? The poor girl who needs saving?

DONALD *(almost laughing)* Emma, you've never needed saving. You need someone to stand beside you and get out of your way.

EMMA That's the most romantic thing anyone has ever said to me.

DONALD *(sincere)* I made a promise when I was fifteen. No woman would ever distract me.

EMMA And?

DONALD And you are the most distracting thing that has ever happened to my life.

She leans in and kisses him, slowly and tenderly. The tension of the whole story breaks. They rest their foreheads together.

EMMA *(whispering)* After Friday, you're taking me on a real date. Not suya in a conference room.

DONALD *(smiling)* I liked the suya.

EMMA So did I.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

Friday

INT. EVERYS — GRAND HALL — SHAREHOLDERS' MEETING — DAY

Hundreds of shareholders. TV cameras. Flashing lights. Marcus Vane walks in wearing a white suit and a perfect smile and shakes hands like a man who already owns the room. Donald, at the podium, watches him.

Michael and Geoffrey are in the front row. Charles is at the side with a tablet. Ross's chair is empty.

GEOFFREY *(whispering)* Where's Ross?

MICHAEL *(checking his phone)* He's not answering.

Donald's eyes go to Emma's seat. It's empty too.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The Message

INT. EVERYS — LADIES' RESTROOM — 20 MINUTES EARLIER

Emma fixes her hair in the mirror. Her phone buzzes. The message is from ROSS.

ON SCREEN

**Emma. They have Debby. Old Apapa wharf, Shed 9.
Come alone. If you tell Donald, she dies. I'm
so sorry.**

Emma stares at it with her hand over her mouth. She tries to call Donald. The call goes straight to voicemail because his phone is off for the meeting. She looks at the door and then at her phone.

EMMA *(to herself, terrified)* Ross... did you do it again?

She makes a decision. She takes the silver fountain pen from her bag, scribbles on a sticky note and runs out.

GUESS THE TWIST

Did Ross really send that text?

☐ Yes, he betrayed her again

☐ No, someone used his phone

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The Note

INT. EVERYS — GRAND HALL — PRESENT

Adaeze rushes to the stage and slips Donald a sticky note. It's stuck to Ross's silver fountain pen. Donald reads it.

WRITTEN NOTE

Apapa. Shed 9. Debby. Don't be angry. — E.

Donald's face drains of colour. At that exact moment, Marcus Vane looks across the hall at him, raises his glass slightly and smiles.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

Powerless

INT. EVERYS — GRAND HALL / BACKSTAGE — DAY

Donald grips the podium. He goes ahead with the plan, because Emma would want him to.

DONALD Ladies and gentlemen. For fourteen months, someone has been stealing from this company to make it cheap enough to buy. That man is sitting in this room. *(He points.)* Marcus Vane.

Uproar. Cameras swing toward Marcus. Geoffrey's evidence fills the giant screen. Marcus doesn't flinch. He walks calmly to the stage, leans in close to Donald and slides his own phone across the podium.

On the screen is a VIDEO. Emma is being dragged into a white van, kicking and screaming.

MARCUS *(whispering, smiling for the cameras)* Withdraw everything. Sign Every's over to me for one naira. You have until midnight. Or you'll never see her again.

Marcus straightens, waves at the cameras and walks out.

BACKSTAGE. Donald slams through a door and braces himself against the wall. His breathing goes ragged. FLASHBACK: the kerosene lamp, the policemen, his mother screaming.

DONALD *(shaking)* Not again... not again...

Michael and Geoffrey burst in. Michael grabs his shoulders.

MICHAEL Donald. Look at me. LOOK AT ME. The rooftop. Promise number five.

GEOFFREY We protect each other. Whatever it costs.

Donald looks at his brothers. His breathing slows. His eyes harden.

The door crashes open. ROSS staggers in with a bloody face and a torn shirt.

ROSS That message wasn't from me! They took my phone this morning! They beat me and left me in a gutter on Ozumba Mbadiwe!

DONALD *(grabbing him)* Where is she?

ROSS Not Apapa. Apapa is a trap. Marcus never keeps people where he says. *(gasping)* He has an old boatyard in Epe. That's where he's keeping Debby. That's where Emma is.

The Price (return)

INT. ABANDONED BOATYARD WAREHOUSE, EPE — NIGHT — HEAVY RAIN

We are back in the cold open, now in full context. Emma is tied to the chair. Across from her, DEBBY is tied up too, crying and bruised. The phone on the oil drum rings: "DONALD."

MARCUS Answer it, Miss Reardon. Tell him the price.
V.O., through
speaker

EMMA He won't pay. Donald Irwin doesn't pay ransoms.

MARCUS Donald Irwin has never had anything worth paying for. *(beat)* Until you.
V.O.

The ringing stops. Emma looks at Debby.

EMMA *(whispering)* Debby. Look at me. Ross didn't send that message, did he?

DEBBY *(sobbing)* They took his phone. He'd never... he loves you like a daughter.

Emma closes her eyes. Relief and heartbreak hit her together. Then she opens them and starts quietly twisting her wrists against the rope, which is rubbing on a rusted edge of the chair.

EMMA *(barely audible)* Count the guards, Debby. Count them for me.

DEBBY ...Two. One by the door. One outside smoking.

EMMA Numbers don't lie.

The Stall

INT. MICHAEL'S RANGE ROVER, LEKKI-EPE EXPRESSWAY — NIGHT

Rain and wipers. Michael drives like a madman. Geoffrey is in the back with a laptop. Donald is on the phone, and Ross sits beside him.

DONALD *(on the phone, voice steady)* Marcus. You win. I'll sign. But I need proof she's alive.

MARCUS Smart boy. Your father would be proud.
V.O.

Donald's jaw clenches. He doesn't react.

GEOFFREY *(whispering)* Keep him talking. Thirty more seconds.

MICHAEL And I have a drone crew shooting a film in Epe this week. Infrared cameras. *(He presses his earpiece.)* Tunde, get the bird in the air. Now!

GEOFFREY *(looking up)* Got him. Old Ikosi boatyard. Ross was right.

Donald hangs up and looks at the black road ahead.

DONALD Michael. Faster.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

Caught

INT. BOATYARD WAREHOUSE — NIGHT

Emma's rope snaps. She quickly frees Debby. They creep toward a side door, and the guard by the main door has his back turned. Emma's hand is on the handle. Then the click of a gun behind them.

MARCUS Leaving so soon?

MARCUS VANE steps out of the darkness in his white suit, now speckled with rain. His men drag the women back.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The Truth About Marcus

INT. BOATYARD WAREHOUSE — CONTINUOUS

Marcus pulls up a crate and sits facing Emma as if they're having tea.

EMMA Why do you hate him so much?

MARCUS Hate? *(laughs)* Fifteen years ago, I bid on the Lagos Port contract. My father's company. My family's name. Three generations of money. And a boy from Ajegunle, with a cheap suit and a borrowed laptop, took it from me in one meeting. They laughed at me in every club in Ikoyi.

EMMA So this is about your pride.

MARCUS This is about order. Men like him are supposed to serve men like me.

EMMA *(leaning forward)* No. You were handed everything, and he still beat you. *(beat)* That's what you can't forgive. Not him. Yourself.

Marcus's smile vanishes. He slaps her hard. Then, from outside—

The low hum of a DRONE overhead.

Marcus looks up.

GUESS THE TWIST

Donald is coming. Who will get hurt?

- ☐ Donald
- ☐ Ross
- ☐ Michael
- ☐ Marcus

The Brothers Arrive

INT/EXT. BOATYARD WAREHOUSE — NIGHT

The main doors burst open. Headlights flood in. Donald walks through the rain with no weapon and no fear on his face. Michael and Geoffrey are on either side of him and Ross is behind them. Sirens wail in the distance.

Marcus grabs Emma, pulls her up and presses a gun to her temple.

MARCUS Stop! One more step, Irwin!

Donald stops. He looks at Emma. Her eyes say, "I'm okay."

DONALD You wanted me powerless, Marcus. You've waited fifteen years to see me on my knees.

He slowly lowers himself to his knees in the wet concrete.

DONALD Here I am. *(beat)* But look around you.

Marcus glances sideways. Police torches are flooding the windows. INSPECTOR BELLO's voice comes through a megaphone: "Marcus Vane! Armed police! Drop your weapon!"

DONALD I'm on my knees. And I still came. That's the difference between us. Nobody would ever come for you.

Marcus's hand trembles. In that split second, Ross charges from the side and slams into Marcus. The gun goes off. BANG. Ross falls, clutching his shoulder.

EMMA ROSS!

Donald lunges and tackles Marcus to the ground. Michael kicks the gun away. Police pour in. Inspector Bello cuffs Marcus.

MARCUS *(dragged away, screaming)* This isn't over, Irwin! You hear me?!

INSPECTOR BELLO For you, oga, it is very over.

Numbers Don't Lie

EXT. BOATYARD — AMBULANCE LIGHTS — NIGHT

Rain is easing. Paramedics load Ross onto a stretcher, and Debby holds his hand. Emma runs over and kneels beside him.

ROSS *(weak, smiling)* You're okay?

EMMA You took a bullet for me, you foolish old man.

ROSS I owed you more than that. *(beat)* Numbers don't lie, Emma...

EMMA *(tears and a smile)* But people change.

Ross closes his eyes, smiling, as the ambulance doors shut.

Emma turns around. Donald stands behind her, soaked and shaking. She runs into his arms. He holds her as if he'll never let go.

DONALD *(into her hair)* I thought I'd lost you.

EMMA You negotiate like a criminal. I knew you'd find me.

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The Family

INT. HOSPITAL CORRIDOR, IKOYI — DAWN

Emma sits with a bandage on her cheek. DR. and MRS. REARDON rush in and hold her tightly. Then Dr. Reardon sees JAMES standing further down the corridor with his guitar case. Father and son look at each other for a long time.

DR. REARDON *(voice breaking)* James.

JAMES Daddy.

Dr. Reardon walks over. He hesitates, then pulls his son into his arms.

DR. REARDON Six years. I was a fool. Both my children are braver than I am.

Emma watches and cries. Donald stands quietly beside her.

GUESS THE TWIST

Donald is about to propose. What will Emma say?

☐ Yes, straight away

☐ Yes... with a condition

☐ No, it's too soon

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

The Second Rooftop

EXT. EVERYS TOWER — ROOFTOP — SUNSET — SIX WEEKS LATER

Golden light over the Lagos lagoon. Emma steps onto the rooftop, confused, in a white dress. Donald waits, nervous for the first time in his life.

EMMA Adaeze said there was an emergency.

DONALD There is. *(He breathes.)* Twenty-five years ago, on a rooftop in Ajegunle, I made a promise that no woman would ever distract me from my ambitions.

EMMA I remember. You told me.

DONALD I've kept every promise I ever made. *(He kneels and opens a ring box.)* I'd like to break that one. On a rooftop. With you. Emma Reardon, will you marry me?

Emma covers her mouth. A long beat. Then a stubborn smile.

EMMA On one condition.

DONALD *(smiling)* Of course there's a condition.

EMMA You never, ever rewrite my reports in red ink again.

DONALD ...Negotiable.

EMMA Donald!

DONALD Deal. Deal!

EMMA *(laughing and crying)* Yes. Yes!

He slips the ring on her finger. Behind a ventilation unit, Michael and Geoffrey jump out cheering, and Michael pops a bottle of champagne.

One Down

EXT. EVERYS ROOFTOP — CONTINUOUS — SUNSET

The four of them laugh. Charles, Tobi and Adaeze come up the stairs clapping. Emma looks at her ring, then at the silver fountain pen in her other hand. Ross sent it back to her from the hospital with a note: "Sign your first big win with it."

MICHAEL (raising his glass) To Donald. The first of us to fall.

GEOFFREY One down. Two to go.

MICHAEL (laughing) Two? No, no, no. One down, and that's the end. Love is not for me. I'm a free man. Free like a bird.

His phone pings. He glances at it, still smiling. Then the smile freezes.

ON SCREEN

Email. FROM: Sophia Bennett. SUBJECT: "Your studio stole my story. I'll be in your office tomorrow at 9. Don't be late, Mr. McClaren."

Next

EXT. ROOFTOP — CONTINUOUS

Michael stares at the email. Donald reads it over his shoulder and slowly starts to grin.

DONALD Who's Sophia Bennett?

MICHAEL *(pocketing the phone fast)* Nobody. A writer. Small problem. I'll handle it in five minutes.

GEOFFREY *(sipping champagne)* That's exactly what Donald said.

Everyone bursts out laughing. Michael doesn't.

NARRATOR One brother has fallen. But the game is far from over. Because the most dangerous thing in the world... is a man who believes he can't be caught.

The camera pulls away from the rooftop and out over the Lagos skyline at dusk.

SWORN BACHELORS — BOOK TWO: WINGS UNCLIPPED. Coming soon.

END

[↑ Back to scenes](#)

Answer key

Scene 1 → revealed in Scene 32

Who do you think kidnapped Emma? **A jealous business rival.** Marcus Vane, the rival Donald beat fifteen years ago, ordered the kidnapping.

Scene 6 → revealed in Scene 24

Ross's phone flashed one letter: "D". What's going on? **He's hiding something dangerous.** Ross was being blackmailed by Marcus, using Debby's family debts.

Scene 11 → revealed in Scene 24

Who is the mole inside Everys? **Ross, her mentor.** Charles was secretly investigating Ross all along.

Scene 17 → revealed in Scene 18

Did Donald just fire Emma for real? **No, he's playing a bigger game.** He humiliated her on purpose so the real mole would relax.

Scene 30 → revealed in Scene 32

Did Ross really send that text? **No, someone used his phone.** Marcus's men beat Ross and stole his phone. Apapa was a trap.

Scene 36 → revealed in Scene 37

Donald is coming. Who will get hurt? **Ross.** Ross charged Marcus and took the bullet meant for Emma.

Scene 39 → revealed in Scene 40

Donald is about to propose. What will Emma say? **Yes... with a condition.** Only if he stops rewriting her reports in red ink.

Coming next: Sworn Bachelors, Book Two: Wings Unclipped.